



OLD TRADITION

The custom of kissing under mistletoe may be older than you think, for this plant was sacred to the ancient British priests known as the Druids some 2,000 years ago.

Parasitic plants

PARASITIC PLANTS ARE CHEATS. Rather than making their own food using the energy from sunlight, they have developed a means of stealing the food made by other plants, known as host plants. Because they do not need sunlight, many parasitic plants spend most of their lives hidden from sight. They attach themselves to the stems or roots of their host plants by means of suckers, known as haustoria. The haustoria penetrate the host's food channels and absorb the sugars and minerals that the parasitic plant needs to live. The world of parasitic plants is a complicated one. Some plants, such as mistletoe and the eyebrights, are only partly parasitic and are known as hemiparasites. These plants have green leaves, so they can use the Sun's energy to make some food for themselves.



THE STINKING GIANT

The world's heaviest flower is a species of rafflesia, a parasite that lives on the roots of vines in the jungles of southeast Asia. Each flower weighs nearly 15 lb (7 kg), and reaches up to 3 ft (1 m) in diameter. The flower fills the air with a putrid smell that attracts pollinating flies. This plant is the largest of 50 species, all of them completely parasitic.

MAKING A BREAK-IN

Dodder stems spread over their hosts looking like lengths of tangled string. These stems develop haustoria that penetrate their host's food channels. Young dodders have roots to help them become established, but as they grow the roots wither away.

Sepals are thick and fleshy



Dodder flowers



Haustroria penetrating the stem of its host

Giant sepals unfold as the flower opens

